CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

DATA ANALYST IN THE AI ERA

Every company is drowning in data and short on people who can explain what it means.

★ TL;DR — Median around $90K, fully remote-capable, and reachable in a 6–12 month training band. The catch: the basic chart-and-report layer is exactly what AI eats first. ★

THE CAREER GLITCH TAKE

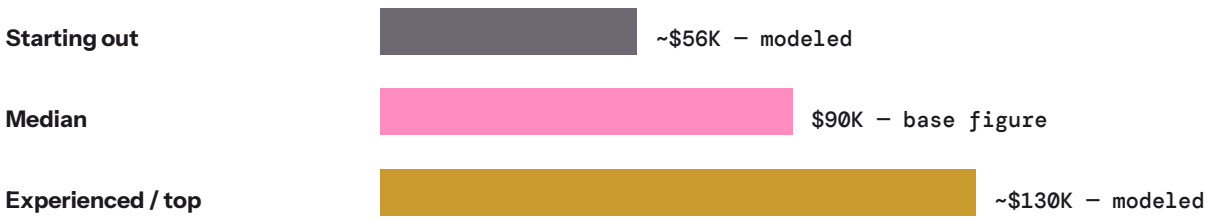
OUR TAKE: YES

MEDIAN ~$90K · TRAINING 6-12 months · AI RISK MEDIUM · CERTIFICATE

- Companies hire analysts who turn messy data into decisions, not people who make pretty charts.
- Entry-level reporting is getting automated fast — SQL plus business sense is the defensible layer.
- AI writes the query; the analyst who knows which question matters keeps the job.

The site's take, built from this profession's numbers in the Career Glitch base.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



The Career Glitch base figure for Data Analyst is a ~$90K median (compiled from U.S. labor-market data (this title has no separate BLS occupation; the figure is a market/anchor estimate)). The starting and top bars are modeled around that median — orientation, not a promise. Pay swings hard by state, employer and experience: check live postings in your state before planning around any number.

WHAT DOES A DATA ANALYST ACTUALLY DO?

✓ Pull data with SQL and clean up the mess before anyone can use it

✓ Build dashboards and recurring reports in a BI tool

✓ Answer ad-hoc questions from marketing, sales and ops teams

✓ Present findings in plain language to people who hate spreadsheets

Think: a translator between databases and bosses — the data speaks SQL, the boss speaks money.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
AI now drafts queries, builds standard dashboards and writes the first summary of any dataset. Routine weekly reporting is disappearing as a human task.	Knowing which metric is lying, why sales dipped in one region, and what question the business actually needs answered. Context and judgment stay human.

⚠ **A certificate alone gets you almost nothing — hiring managers filter on portfolio projects and SQL fluency, not course completions.**

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT
✓ Fully remote work from anywhere ✓ Regular hours, no on-call culture in most teams ✓ A front-row seat to how a business really runs	✗ Half the job is cleaning dirty data nobody warned you about ✗ Stakeholders asking for a dashboard, then never opening it ✗ Meetings where your chart is argued with, not read

Good fit? You like puzzles, patterns and explaining things clearly, and you are patient with messy, boring raw material.
Bad fit? You want creative work with visible output, or numbers feel like homework you are escaping.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — SKILLS FIRST, THEN APPLY	DOOR B — SIDEWAYS FROM A BUSINESS JOB
Learn SQL, spreadsheets at an advanced level, one BI tool and basic statistics. Build 3–4 portfolio projects on public datasets that end in a recommendation, not just a chart.	If you already work in ops, marketing, finance or support, start automating your own team's reports. Internal movers with domain knowledge beat outside applicants with generic certificates.

Smart move: Pick one industry — retail, healthcare, logistics — and build every portfolio project inside it. Niche analysts get interviews; generalists get ignored.
Where you land after: Senior analyst → analytics manager or a pivot into data science, product analytics or BI leadership.

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
PICK YOUR	SQL UNTIL	DASHBOARDS AND	PORTFOLIO PROJECTS	CERTIFICATE AND	APPLY LIKE

STEP 1 — Pick your stack

FREE · TODAY

- Choose the standard toolkit: SQL, Excel/Sheets, Tableau or Power BI, and a little Python later.
- Set up free tools and one public dataset you actually find interesting.

STEP 2 — SQL until it hurts

FREE-$50 · WEEKS 1-4

- Joins, aggregations, window functions — drill them daily on practice platforms.
- Rewrite every exercise answer a second way; fluency is the whole game.

STEP 3 — Dashboards and statistics basics

FREE-$100 · WEEKS 5-8

- Build two dashboards end-to-end: one operational, one executive summary.
- Learn averages vs medians, correlation vs causation, and how charts lie.

STEP 4 — Portfolio projects

FREE · WEEKS 9-12

- Ship 3 projects, each ending with a written recommendation a manager could act on.
- Publish them where a hiring manager can click, not in a zip file.

STEP 5 — Certificate and interview prep

$100-400 · MONTHS 4-6

- Add a recognized data analytics certificate to formalize the skill set.
- Practice case interviews: clarify the question, structure the analysis, sanity-check the answer.

STEP 6 — Apply like an analyst

FREE · MONTHS 6-12

- Target analyst roles in your chosen industry first.
- Track applications, response rates and interview feedback in — what else — a spreadsheet.

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

- □ Today: install the free tools, pick one industry and one public dataset.
- □ Days 1–30: SQL daily; finish your first cleaned dataset and one basic dashboard.
- □ Days 31–60: second dashboard plus statistics basics; start writing up findings in plain English.
- □ Days 61–90: two portfolio projects published; certificate study underway.
- □ Day 90: a visible portfolio, working SQL, and a target list of companies in one industry.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

- Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest "probably NOT you". → careerglitch.com/#test
- Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ CHARTS ARE CHEAP. ANSWERS ARE NOT. ★

CAREER GLITCH · Figures: Career Glitch profession base (medians and training ranges compiled from U.S. labor-market data (this title has no separate BLS occupation; the figure is a market/anchor estimate)). Modeled bars are estimates around the base median. License and certification rules vary by state — verify with your state board before paying for any program.